

DIVIDE AND BE



RAVI S SAMRAH

■ By Ramesh Vinayak in Jammu and Srinagar

In the tumultuous history of Jammu and Kashmir since its accession to India in 1947, Jammu has stood out as a land of refuge and resilience. It embraced the refugees of the Partition and the Kashmiri Pandits, who were hounded out in a diabolic ethnic cleansing of the Valley in 1990s. It has suffered a series of terror attacks on its most revered Raghunath temple with remarkable fortitude, steadfastly holding on to its tenuous communal moorings. Today, Jammu is cracking up from within. It took the revocation of the government order on land transfer to the Amarnath shrine to unplug its dormant anger. Not since the early 1950s—when the Jan Sangh-supported Praja Parishad led an agitation demanding “*ek samvidhan, ek nishan aur ek pradhan* (one Constitution, one flag and one prime minister)” —has Jammu been rocked by such paroxysm of protests which exposed its communal fault lines. They have also ominously pushed

DEADLY SCHISM: Protests in Srinagar; Kashmiris carry the body of slain Hurriyat leader Aziz (right)

the state to the precipice of a dangerous divide between the Hindu-majority Jammu and the predominantly Muslim Valley.

A fast turn of events have led to the two ethnically and geographically distinct regions being virtually at war today. While Jammu continues to simmer with its restive population showing no signs of fatigue from a six-week-long and economically-crippling bandh, the Valley has plunged into yet another spell of violent anti-India frenzy.

On August 11, a day after an all-party delegation led by Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil wrapped up its two-day visit to the state as part of the UPA Government's belated damage control initiative, with a rehearsed appeal for peace and without even a symbolic breakthrough on the land dispute, violence dramatically escalated in Kashmir, provoking firing by security forces that left five demonstrators dead.